

Q There are a lot of bottles and nipples to choose from for bottle-feeding. What should we look for?

All bottles and nipples can be used with both formula and with breast milk if you have expressed using a pump. There is no right or wrong choice. All of the items will be easy to buy once your baby arrives, so you shouldn't need to stockpile too many supplies before the birth.

Standard baby bottles are popular. These are usually available in a small or large size (around 4oz/125ml and 9oz/260ml), and with these you can tailor feeds depending on your baby's age and stage. Standard bottles usually come with nipples and lids, are easy to clean, and are compatible with most sanitizing systems (see p.279) and bottle coolers. Some bottles are designed to help ease colic by limiting the amount of air your baby swallows with her milk, so these are worth trying for babies who often seem to be unsettled after being fed and have uncomfortable gas. Colic bottles tend to be more expensive, and those that have a valve or tube to adapt the milk flow can be trickier to keep clean. If you have a microwave, consider a self-sanitizing bottle, which can be sanitized in a microwave. Again, these are a bit pricier, but can be convenient. Ready-sanitized disposable bottles are also available; you just add the formula and discard the bottle after use. While useful for traveling, these are expensive and

wasteful if used regularly. Glass bottles, made of toughened glass, are favored by parents who worry about chemicals used in the manufacture of plastic bottles. These are more expensive, and breakable, but more environmentally friendly.

Bottle nipples

Nipples can be silicone or latex and have different flow speeds. Latex nipples tend to be more flexible and softer, but are less durable than silicone. Slow-flow nipples are designed to release the milk more slowly, and are usually best for newborns and young babies. Traditionally, nipples are bell-shaped; wider nipples are available that are thought to resemble the shape of a human nipple more closely, so manufacturers recommend these if you are combining breast and bottle, or trying to move a breast-fed baby over to bottle-feeding. However, it's unlikely a bottle nipple can truly mimic the human nipple and the unique sucking action required, and there's no evidence that these are easier to use.

WHAT YOU NEED

Keep an eye on the condition of your equipment, especially the nipples, and replace them when they become damaged or worn.

» 6-8 bottles in a combination of large and small sizes.

» 6-8 nipples appropriate for newborns.

» Formula powder.

» A sanitizing system—either a cold-water sanitizing system or a steam sanitizer. You can also boil bottle-feeding equipment. See p.279 for how different sanitizing systems work.

» Bottle- and nipple-cleaning brushes.



Feeding bottles These are available in a variety of sizes, while nipples have different flow speeds; keep an eye on which ones help your baby to feed most easily and comfortably.